

The Trouble With Online Education

By Mark Edmundson

“Ah, you’re a professor. You must learn so much from your students.”

This line, which I’ve heard in various forms, always makes me **cringe**(=embarrass, 尴尬). Do people think that lawyers learn a lot about the law from their clients? That patients teach doctors much of what they know about medicine?

Yet **latent**ⁱⁱ in the **sentiment**ⁱⁱⁱ that our students are our teachers is an important truth.ⁱ We do in fact need to learn from them, but not about the history of the Roman Empire or the politics of “Paradise Lost.” Understanding what it is that students have to teach teachers can help us to deal with one of the most **vexing**(=annoying, disturbing 让人恼火的) issues now facing colleges and universities: online education. At my school, the University of Virginia, that issue did more than vex us; it **came close to**^{iv} **tearing** the university **apart**.

i. 该句为倒装句。The sentence can be simplified as “Yet latent in the sentiment ~~that our students are our teachers~~ is an important truth.” We then change it into “Yet an important truth is latent in the sentiment.” 句意为：一重要的真理藏在这样的观点之中。最后，我们再将之前删除的句子填补完整：“Yet an important truth is latent in the sentiment that our students are our teachers.” 句意为：在学生是我们的老师这样的观点里，藏着一个重要真理。

ii. Latent means present but not obvious, 存在而不明显的。

iii. Sentiment here means opinion, idea 此处表示观点。

iv. Come close to means to almost do sth. E.g. We came close to winning the race! 差点就赢了！

A few weeks ago our president, Teresa A. Sullivan, was **summarily**^v **dismissed**(解雇) and then summarily reinstated(=restore 恢复) by the university’s board of visitors. One reason for her **dismissal**(noun form of dismiss) was the perception that she was not moving forward fast enough on Internet learning. Stanford was doing it, Harvard, Yale and M.I.T. too. But Virginia, it seemed, was **lagging**(=falling behind 拖了后腿的). Just this week, in fact, it was announced that Virginia, along with a number of other universities, signed on with a company called Coursera to develop and offer online classes.

v. Summarily means in a way which is done quickly without delay.

But can online education ever^{vi} be education of the very best sort?

vi. Ever here is an emphasis 表示强调。E.g. I am ever happy to see you = I am really happy to see you. 原句 “But can online education ever be education of the very best sort” = But can online education be the best sort?

It’s here that the **notion**(=sentiment 观点) of students teaching teachers is **illuminating**^{vii}. As a friend and fellow professor said to me: “You don’t just teach students, you have to learn from them too.” It took a minute — it sounded like he was channeling Huck Finn— but I figured it out.

vii. Illuminating means being formative, inspiring 信息量足的，启发人思考的

With every class we teach, we need to learn who the people in front of us are. We need to know where they are **intellectually**^{viii}, who they are as people and what we can do to help them grow. Teaching, even when you have a group of a hundred students on hand, is a matter

of dialogue.

viii. Here, intellectual can be understood as being capable for rational or intelligent thought 能够进行理性思维的, 那么 intellectually 其实指的就是思考能力或者智力水平。

In the summer Shakespeare course I'm teaching now, I'm **constantly** working to figure out what my students are able to do and how they can develop. Can they **grasp**(=master, 掌握) the contours(=outline, frame 概要) of Shakespeare's plots? If not, **it's worth**^{ix} adding a well-made film version of the next play to the syllabus. Is the language hard for them, line to line? Then we have to spend more time **going over**(=examine, check) individual speeches word by word. Are they **adept**^x at understanding the plot and the language? Time to introduce them to the complexities(复杂性) of Shakespeare's rendering(=representation 呈现) of character.^{xi}

ix. Be worth doing, or be worth sth, means deserve to do or deserve sth 值得. E.g. Is the prize worth the effort? = Does the prize deserve our efforts? 这个奖值得花功夫吗?

x. 我们做一个词形辨析:

Adapt to means to make fit, 适应;

Adopt means to begin to practise, put into effect, implement, 实施;

Adept is an adj., which means proficient, expert, skillful, 熟练的, 有技巧的;

xi. The last sentence can be paraphrased as such:

It is time to introduce the students to see how Shakespeare shaped his characters and how complex those roles were.

Every **memorable** class is a bit like a jazz **composition**. There is **the basic melody**(主旋律) that you work with. It is **defined**(=determine) by the syllabus. But there is also a considerable measure of **improvisation** against that **disciplining**^{xii} background.

xii. Disciplining here means controlled, ordered 基于规则、限制的基础之上的。那么, 这里的“规则”或者“限制”是什么? 是 that disciplining background 中的前指代词 “that,” 它指代 syllabus 教学大纲, 即基于不同学科的教学大纲基础之上, 老师们需要有即兴发挥。

Something similar **applies** even **to** larger courses. We tend to think that the spellbinding lecturers we had in college survey classes were **gifted**(=talented) actors who could strut and fret 50 amazing minutes on the stage. But I think that the best of those lecturers are highly adept at reading their audiences. They use practical means to do this — tests and quizzes, papers and evaluations. But they also **deploy**(=use, employ) something tantamount (=equivalent, identical, same) to artistry(=artistic quality 具备艺术性质). They are **superb**^{xiii} at sensing the mood of a room. They have a sort of pedagogical sixth sense. They feel it when the class is **engaged**^{xiv} and when it **slips off**(溜走, 开小差). And they do something about it. Their every joke is a sounding. It's a way of **discerning**^{xv} who is out there on a given day.

xiii. Superb means having high degree of excellent;

xiv. Engaged here is an adj., which means concentrated, focused;

xv. Discern means to detect, recognise, 察觉, 识别。

A large lecture class can also create **genuine** intellectual community. Students will always be **running across** others who are also **enrolled**(=register for a course 登记选课), and they'll **break the ice**(打破僵局) with a chat about it and maybe they'll go on from there. When a

teacher hears a student say, “My friends and I are always arguing about your class,” he knows he’s doing something right. From there he folds what he has learned into his teaching, **adjusting** his course in a fluid and immediate way that the Internet professor cannot easily **match**.

Online education is a one-size-fits-all^{xvi} **endeavor**^{xv}. It tends to be a **monologue**(独白, 与 **dialogue** 呈反义词) and not a real dialogue. The Internet teacher, even one who **responds to** students via e-mail, can never have the immediacy of contact that the teacher on the scene can, with his sensitivity to **unspoken** moods and enthusiasms. This is particularly true of online courses for which the lectures are already filmed and in the can. It doesn’t matter who is sitting out there on the Internet watching; the course is what it is.

xvi. One-size-fits-all means being suitable for all people. 均码;

xv. Here, endeavor means activity.

Not long ago I watched a pre-filmed online course from Yale about the New Testament. It was a very good course. The instructor was hyper-intelligent, learned and **splendidly articulate**^{xvi}. But the course wasn’t great and could never have been. There were Yale students on hand for the filming, but the class seemed addressed to no one in particular. It had an **anonymous**(lacking individuality, distinction 无特色的) quality. In fact there was nothing you could get from that course that you couldn’t get from a good book on the subject.^{xviii}

xvi. Articulate means expressing oneself readily, clearly and effectively 口齿伶俐, 舌灿莲花;

xvii. On hand means present, in attendance, 在场的; in hand means in one’s possession, 在手里的, 在掌控之中的; at hand means within reach, 手边的.

xviii. 这个句子是一个双重否定句, 双重否定等于肯定句。所以, 我们将这个句子还原成肯定句, 于是就变成了:

There were **many things** you could get from the course of New Testament **that** you could get from a good book on that subject. 所以, 该句中的 that 引导定语从句, 修饰 **many things**. 也就是说, 你能从那一节新约课里学到的, 也能从一本该主题的好书里学到。

A truly **memorable** college class, even a large one, is a **collaboration** between teacher and students. It’s a one-time-only event. Learning at its best is a **collective enterprise** (=collaborated effort), something we’ve known since Socrates. You can get knowledge from an Internet course if you’re highly motivated to learn. But in real courses the students and teachers come together and create an **immediate**^{xix} and **vital**^{xx} community of learning. A real course creates intellectual joy, at least in some. I don’t think an Internet course ever will. Internet learning **promises to**^{xxi} make intellectual life more **sterile**(=dull, lifeless) and abstract than it already is — and also, for teachers and for students alike, far more lonely.

xix. Here, immediate does not mean fast, quick; it means current, direct, 直接的, 实时的, 临近的, 手边的

xx. Vital means animated, invigorating, 充满生机的.

xxi. Here, promise to does not mean pledge or vow to do, 不是发誓, 或者允诺; it means to be expected to, 预示着, 常表示贬义。例如: Such policy promises to bring adversity to the poor. 这样的政策对穷人来说是一场灾难。